



Freelance Business: Contracts, Scope & Clients

AVC 248 · Design Self-Promotion · Week 9

“Get it in writing, every single time.”

Freelance vs. employment

Both can build a great creative career. They just run on very different rules, and you should know which one you are stepping into.



EMPLOYMENT

Steady, supported, shared

A salary, benefits, and a team. Your employer handles taxes, tools, and finding the work. You trade some freedom for stability.



FREELANCE

Free, flexible, on you

You pick clients and rates, but you also chase the work, set the terms, and cover your own taxes, gear, and downtime.

The freedom is real. So is the paperwork.

WHY IT MATTERS

A contract protects both of you

A standard operating contract is not about distrust. It sets shared expectations so a project stays calm, fair, and finishable.

You

know exactly what to make, by when, and for how much.

Them

know what they get, what it costs, and what is out of scope.

Both

have one document to point to when memory gets fuzzy.

Next: the seven points every client contract should name.

Seven points to settle up front

Before any work starts, talk these through with your client and write them down. Each one prevents a different argument later.



Scope of work



Deliverables



Timeline & milestones



Payment & deposit



Number of revisions



Usage & rights



A kill fee

Name all seven and the contract can finally do its job.

Scope, deliverables, and timeline



Scope of work

Exactly what you will do, and just as importantly what you will not. Spell out anything outside this as billable extra work.



Deliverables

The concrete files they receive: formats, sizes, source files, and whether print-ready or web-ready. No guessing at the finish line.



Timeline & milestones

Key dates and check-ins, not just a final due date. Milestones keep feedback flowing and the project on track.

Money, revisions, rights, and exits

These four points are where most freelance disputes actually happen. Settle them in writing and you protect your time and your work.



Payment & deposit

A deposit up front, then clear due dates. Never start real work unpaid.



Revisions

State how many rounds are included. Extra rounds are billed.



Usage & rights

Who owns the work, and where it can be used. License or transfer.



Kill fee

If they cancel mid-project, you still get paid for work done.

The spec sheet and project brief

Two short documents turn a vague request into a real plan. They live alongside the contract and keep everyone honest.



PROJECT BRIEF

The why and the who

Goals, audience, brand voice, and references. It captures what success looks like before you open a single file.



SPEC SHEET

The what and the how

Exact sizes, formats, color modes, fonts, and file naming. The technical truth your deliverables must match.

Hourly vs. project pricing

There is no single right answer. Pick the model that fits the work and the client, and make sure it covers more than just your time.



HOURLY

Pay for the time

Best when scope is fuzzy or likely to change. Track your hours honestly and set a rate that covers taxes and slow weeks.



PROJECT

Pay for the result

Best when scope is clear. You quote one price for the whole job, so efficiency works in your favor, not against you.

Finding and keeping clients

New clients are expensive to win. The freelancers who last are the ones repeat clients keep coming back to.



Find them

Referrals, your portfolio, and your network. Most good work comes from people who already trust you.



Serve them well

Clear communication, hit deadlines, and no surprises on the invoice. Professionalism is your real marketing.



Keep them

Follow up, deliver clean files, and stay easy to work with. A happy client is your next three projects.



Clear terms make freelancing freeing.

“Protect the work, and the work pays you back.”